services. A change to a policy or signal could affect behavior across multiple systems, users, and contexts. Traditional testing approaches, which focused on individual code paths, were no longer sufficient to ensure consistent outcomes.

In response, ACME invested in policy-aware testing practices (as discussed in chapter 14). Policy changes were evaluated using representative scenarios and historical decision data to assess their impact before deployment. Simulation and staged rollouts were introduced to reduce risk, allowing teams to observe how decisions performed under real-world conditions. These practices did not eliminate uncertainty, but they helped manage authorization pressure by making changes safer, more predictable, and easier to reason about.

None of these elements eliminated complexity. ACME's ecosystem continued to grow. New partnership models introduced new forms of delegation. Agent-assisted workflows created new categories of risk. But the organization now had an architecture capable of adapting to these changes. Authorization was no longer a collection of local solutions; it had become a shared foundation for building new capabilities.

What began as incremental responses to immediate needs had produced something more powerful: a shared capability for controlling how people, services, and agents act across the company's systems.

19.3 When the CIO and CISO finally agreed

The quarterly board meeting had already run long. Financial performance was strong. The Customer Collaboration platform continued to grow at a faster pace than forecast. ACME's expansion into partner-led distribution had opened new markets, and the early deployments of agent-assisted workflows were showing measurable gains in productivity. The discussion had moved past revenue and product plans and into a topic that, not long ago, would never have appeared on the board agenda: *operational trust, security, and risk.*